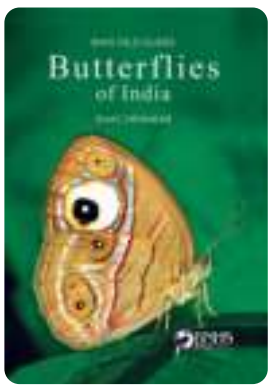
Society (BNHS), which then led to an offer for a full-time job there. "There I was, right amidst a treasure of books as a library assistant! I was lapping up as much as I could from the library and watching people like celebrated ornithologist Dr Salim Ali at work when he visited BNHS," he recalls. "Working with the BNHS for 38 years



until I retired as the deputy director (Natural History), I got the opportunity to travel to some of the places of my dreams," shares the author of six books, including the definitive field guides, *Common Indian Wild Flowers* and *Butterflies of India*.

It was Bittu Sahgal, editor of *Sanctuary Asia* magazine, who got him writing about butterflies. "While working on the story of the butterfly lifecycle, I became fascinated with them and, then onwards, butterflies took over my life," he says. Today, as co-founder and director of the iNaturewatch Foundation, Kehimkar works on improving urban biodiversity and encouraging 'citizen science'. "Butterflies are closely linked to the plant

"THE FILM IS ABOUT ME **USING BUTTERFLIES** TO MAKE PEOPLE FALL IN LOVE WITH NATURE," SAYS KEHIMKAR

population. It's important to have areas left as wild patches for butterflies to flourish. Even the establishing of more open-air gardens would help the city's butterfly population," he points out. ■

—Priya Pathiyan

Q+A

"BANU WRITES IN A LANGUAGE OF THE PEOPLE"

Deepa Bhasthi on translating Banu Mushtaq's *Heart Lamp*, which won the 2025 International Booker Prize

Q. You've spoken about how Banu Mushtaq's Kannada has generous doses of other languages: Hindi, Urdu, Dakhni et al. As a translator, how did it affect your work?

Actually, it was easier for me, because the Kannada that Banu writes in is a language of the people, of the streets. It follows the rhythms of actual speech...a living, breathing language that you get to observe first-hand for yourself.

Q. Mushtaq's protagonists are often older women re-evaluating their lives. Is it fair to say redemption is a major theme of *Heart Lamp*?

That's a nice way to put it. These women, in their 40s or 50s, are really growing into their skins. They finally understand what they want and why, what are the things/people holding them back.

Q. Your win will inevitably put the spotlight on Kannada literature...what will new readers discover about this world?

Like a lot of Indian languages, Kannada has an extremely wide range of genres and styles, including a lot of experimental writing as well. I hope new readers arrive at that kind of writing, eventually—novels and short stories that break new ground in terms of both form and content.

—with Aditya Mani Jha


AFP


AFP

THE SIDESPIN Suravajjula in action at a WTT event; (extreme left) Thakkar celebrates a win

er, Manav Thakkar made a deep run into the semis, the first Indian male paddler to achieve the feat at a Star Contender tournament. By the end of the week, he achieved his career-best ranking of World No. 47, the mark of a rapidly improving player, who is also the World No. 10 in doubles alongside his partner, Manush Shah. "I was struggling in the initial matches. But over the last few months, I've been working on my mental preparations, for days when I'm not at my best," says Thakkar.

Thakkar, Shah and Suravajjula have known each other since their junior days and have been mentored by Achanta at different moments of their careers. The trio has also been gaining vital exposure on the European club circuit—while Suravajjula plays in Austria, Thakkar and Shah ply their trade in France and the Czech Republic, respectively. "Manav and I train independently, but we've been playing together since our under-15 days," says Shah, who was crowned national champion in January. "If one of us beats a top player, it motivates the others also, pushes them to target similar results," adds Suravajjula. ■

—Shail Desai